

THIRD EYE **ISHANKKAR AIYAR**

Flyover Politics

It could be lazy politics, vote-bank economics, simple ideological bankruptcy or all of the above. Whatever the reason, the political class is once again afflicted by the quota rash. The current rush first sparked by the Women's Reservation Bill passed in the Rajya Sabha is being fuelled by a debate around the case in the Supreme Court on the legal sanctity of a 4 per cent quota for Muslims legislated by Andhra Pradesh. There is a predictability with which political parties chary of addressing real issues race to devote time, energy and manpower to rattle rhetoric on weary voters.

Six decades after Independence, political parties and politicians are underlining their failure to get the system to deliver by revisiting ideas of the past. The world over, voters are being wooed with hope of change. Indian voters looking for a vision are being lured with instruments of division. The discourse on affirmative action is old and contentious. One may have two opinions on whether there is merit in reservations but can there be two opinions on the imperative to examine whether quotacracy has delivered?

Last fortnight, the National Council for Applied Economic Research released a study done with the University of Maryland which revealed that "nearly one third of Muslims in the nation live below the poverty line on less than Rs 550 a month" and "those in villages survive on Rs 338 a month". To many politicians this was perfect rationale to justify a quota for Muslims. Perhaps. But the same study also revealed that over 50 per cent of Adivasi and 32 per cent of Dalits are living below the poverty line, despite 60 years of quotas. Is it any surprise that the worst Naxal-hit districts or the "sickle belt" is where the tribal population is the highest? The battle for Mandal reservations was fought and won on the Gangetic

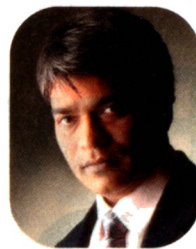
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plains, but have reservations delivered the desired result? Why is it that the majority of the poorest and most illiterate districts of the country are located in the north?

Clearly, there is a widening chasm between diagnosis of poverty and the prescription of quotas. Sure there are exceptions. The tribals in the North-east have done well and so have oBCs in the south. The difference is quality of governance, in delivery of simple services like healthcare, education and access to employment opportunities.

It is not that politicians are unaware but quite obviously find fixing problems of governance tedious and time-consuming. Politicians clearly prefer the renewable mantra of quotacracy, create quotas like flyovers to overcome incumbency for a smooth ride. Until the next political jam!



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SIGNPOSTS

IMPLEMENTED: The Right to Education Act, which will ensure free and compulsory education as a fundamental right of every child in the 6-14 age group and will earmark 25 per cent of seats to children from economically weaker sections in private schools.

LISTED: Lakshmi Mittal, owner of the world's largest steel company ArcelorMittal, as the richest Asian in Britain for 2010, according to the Asian



Rich List 2010 brought out by Eastern Eye, a publication of the Asian Media & Marketing Group.

WON: By the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation, the Most Improved Metro award at the third Metro Awards ceremony in London.

APPOINTED: Islam A. Siddiqui as chief agricultural negotiator in the Office of the US Trade Representative. He is a graduate from the Uttar Pradesh Agricultural University in Pantnagar.